stoke their fears about the American intentions regarding the non-proliferation regime, in the hope that it might encourage American camp followers to revolt against the Indo–US nuclear deal. They also played on European fears about the repercussions of a dilution of the non-proliferation regime in terms of increasing the likelihood of a nuclear attack by irresponsible countries. It was always careful to show itself as a responsible member of the international community and to couch the argument in terms of international peace and security. This is a psychological pressure tactic that China employs; it suggests that the bigger power (in this case the Americans) is a bully and it aids and abets the smaller countries concerned to demonstrate that they are not subservient. China then uses the 'opposition' generated in this way to secure concessions from the larger party, in this case the Americans. At least some of the amendments to the original US draft that were suggested by Austria, New Zealand, Ireland and the others, may have come directly or through more subtle means from China. In other words, China was able to secure these concessions not by directly negotiating with America, but by getting others to do their work for them.

China's experience and, more importantly, understanding, of how to manoeuvre in multilateral negotiations is steadily improving. It has also been a key proponent of using the principle of 'consensus' as leverage or to block progress on multilateral issues that do not suit their interests. China has been successful in changing the definition of 'consensus' from one meaning the largest possible majority to a more authoritarian definition that means every last one in the room. This allows the Chinese to paralyse international negotiations, compels others to approach China for relief and enables the Chinese to extract concessions in return even when they are the lone ones standing out. The principle of democratic majority is